In the first place, the formation of a black capitalism has been consolidated. This is made up of the local partners of the multinational corporations who capture a portion of the pillaged resources. In many countries, mining and petroleum regulations have been reformed in order to increase this slice, which also serves to nourish a process of primitive accumulation. This has led, in certain countries, to significant participation by local bourgeoisies. South Africa leads this group, but Nigeria is also strengthening its gravitational pull.

Second, China's arrival has changed the balance of forces between the local dominant elites, on the one hand, and the United States and the old colonial powers on the other. This new player is investing in the continent, purchasing enormous quantities of primary materials and offering infrastructure credits without the conditions attached by the World Bank. The section of the new African bourgeoisie which is more closely linked to the West is contesting those who support developing closer ties with the Asian giant. China, however, has an advantage in that it does not carry the baggage of being a former colonial power.

Third, a significant change in the economic conjuncture has been produced in the last decade. The rate of growth began to recover, reaching an annual average of 5.1%, which beat the world average of 3% and which is an enormous improvement compared to its regression between 1980 and 1990. This rise accompanied strong growth in investments in extractive industries, which jumped from US$7 to US$62 billion, all in the context of a widespread transformation of agriculture. Imports increased 16% per year and the terms of trade improved by 38% compared to 2000–12.[29]

These modifications have changed the ideological climate of 'Afro-pessimism', which presented the tearing apart of the continent as an unavoidable destiny. Now, a version of 'Afro-optimism' is exuded by the neoliberal elites, auguring in a charmed future. If the first theory blamed the recurrent pillaging of Africa on self-flagellation and cynical opportunism, the second only serves to sanction it as the starting point for escaping underdevelopment.[30] This last vision is responsible for disseminating all kinds of fantasies about the imminent appearance of middle classes and forgets the abysmal prevailing social conditions in the highest-growth nations. Sixty per cent of the population in Angola and Nigeria live in poverty. Nigeria has the highest proportion of its citizens living in emergency housing on the entire continent and 80% lack potable water. Moreover, youth unemployment averages 60%. In the countryside, the situation is even worse because of the huge demographic pressure on cultivable land, reduced renewable water reserves, and widespread deforestation.[31]